

Running a global PMO across Official, Secret and Top Secret at the FCDO

How unified governance and assurance kept a multi-supplier IT portfolio predictable, transparent and secure across one of the UK Government's most complex delivery landscapes.

My role	Client	Classifications	Line-managed team
PMO Manager	Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office	Official, Secret, Top Secret	30 people

Overview

As PMO Manager for the Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office (FCDO), I led governance and delivery oversight of a global IT project portfolio that operated across multiple security classifications: Official, Secret and Top Secret.

The role demanded exceptional coordination across a multi-MSP environment. Each managed service provider delivered a distinct operational line into BAE Systems, the sole service integrator for the FCDO's technology ecosystem.

The environment

The engagement sat within one of the UK Government's most complex delivery landscapes: a multi-vendor, multi-disciplinary environment supporting secure global operations.

Key characteristics

- Multiple Managed Service Providers (MSPs) delivering business-as-usual support across diverse technology domains.
- Integration through BAE Systems as the single service integrator.
- A global delivery footprint spanning secure and classified networks.
- Projects ranging from infrastructure upgrades to cyber-security and collaboration platforms.

Operating here required robust governance, precise coordination and disciplined assurance to maintain operational integrity across every service line.

Portfolio governance and assurance

I established and managed the governance framework for the whole project portfolio, ensuring compliance with FCDO, BAE Systems and Cabinet Office standards.

Responsibilities

- Oversight of the project lifecycle from initiation to closure.
- SLA management and performance tracking across MSPs.
- Risk, issue and dependency management across classified domains.
- Assurance reviews and reporting to senior government stakeholders.
- Continuous improvement of delivery processes and governance artefacts.

The framework gave the programme transparency, accountability and delivery confidence in a highly regulated environment.

Stakeholder and vendor management

Working across a multi-vendor, multi-agency ecosystem, I managed relationships with government officials, service integrator teams and third-party suppliers.

Stakeholder groups

- BAE Systems (service integrator).
- Multiple MSPs delivering operational support.
- Senior government officials and departmental leads.
- Security and compliance authorities.

Structured engagement and clear communication channels kept strategic objectives and operational execution aligned.

Leadership and resource management

I provided direct line management and matrix leadership across a diverse technical and delivery workforce.

Line management

- 2 Business Analysts
- 1 Change Analyst
- 10 Project Managers
- 2 Project Coordinators
- 15 Technical Consultants

Matrix management

- Wintel Engineers
- Network Engineers
- Messaging and Collaboration Engineers
- Security Engineers

This structure supported efficient use of resources, cross-functional collaboration and consistent delivery standards across all workstreams.

Outcomes and impact

- Established unified PMO governance across a multi-MSP environment.
- Improved SLA compliance and delivery predictability.
- Enhanced visibility of global project portfolio performance.
- Strengthened collaboration between the FCDO, BAE Systems and third-party vendors.
- Delivered assured outcomes across Official, Secret and Top Secret domains.

Strategic contribution

The engagement delivered a mature, secure and integrated PMO capability supporting the FCDO's global mission.

It reinforced governance discipline, improved service integration and ensured delivery excellence across one of the UK Government's most complex technology portfolios.